and half-truths in *Thirteen Days.*'[33] Costner's film also reinforces the popular and enduring image of John F. Kennedy as a heroic figure, tragically lost to the American nation, with consequences that included involvement in the avoidable tragedy of the Vietnam War. That, however, is another story.

'I wouldn't start from here. And I wouldn't go today.'

When and where should the study of the Cuban missile crisis begin? Robert Kennedy's *Thirteen Days* begins on the morning of Tuesday 16 October 1962 (when JFK learned of the Soviet missiles) and provides an account of events in the White House. Kevin Costner's *Thirteen Days* also begins on the morning of Tuesday 16 October. It also depicts events in the White House. The only senior Soviets to merit any dialogue are Foreign Minister Gromyko in the White House on 18 October, Ambassador Zorin in the UN Security Council on 25 October, and Ambassador Dobrynin, when he meets Robert Kennedy on 27 October. Neither Nikita Khrushchev nor Fidel Castro manages an appearance. The only Cubans we get to see are those preparing the Soviet missile sites (which in the real world they did not) and those letting loose with all their weapons at the first sight of low-level US reconnaissance aircraft (which in the real world they did not).

If the story of the crisis begins on Tuesday 16 October, it is easy to portray Kennedy as the victim of Khrushchev's duplicity and aggression. The Soviet Premier had provided repeated public and private assurances during 1962 (including through trusted secret 'back-channels') that he would not deploy 'offensive' weapons in Cuba, or indeed do anything to undermine the Democrats in the mid-term Congressional elections in November.

If the story begins in April 1961 (with the CIA-sponsored invasion of Cuba at the Bay of Pigs), or in November 1961 (with the attempted overthrow of Castro in Operation Mongoose), then it is Kennedy who provides the duplicity and aggression. These were also apparent in the efforts of the CIA to procure the assassination of Fidel Castro, including